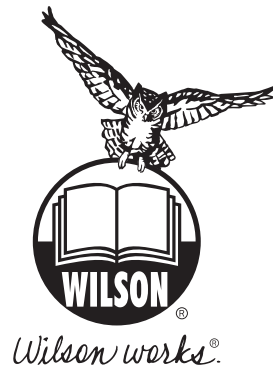


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A Fine Time on the Slope PART ONE

Stan and Kate did like to slide down hills. One day, the sun shone so it was not too cold. Yet, there sure was still a lot of snow everywhere. It was too fine of a day to waste!

Stan and Kate removed their sleds from the shed. The red sled was Kate's and the black one was Stan's. The two friends set off to walk down the lane to find a big hill. While they pulled their sleds, they could not help but think of the thrill to come. At last, they made it to the bottom of a great hill. It was quite a hike, but they pushed on until they got to the top.

Stan and Kate had the sleds set to take off at the top of the slope. Kate used her hands to push Stan. Off he went! Next, Kate sat on her sled and used her legs to set off down the slope as well. The sleds went at a fast rate and it was nonstop fun, even though they had to drag the sleds back up to the top of the slope after each run.

Were these two friends done with their fun?

A Fine Time on the Slope PART TWO

The next time the pals slid down the hill, Stan had an unexpected spill. His sled twisted to the right and sent him into a big snow drift. Yet, this mild crash did not make him stop. He got up quick to get unstuck from the drift, but a small misstep landed him in a pile of wet slush. Kate called out to Stan, “You sure do scare me!”

Stan used his hat to remove the cold snow and water from his pants and jacket. After this, Stan strode right back up the hill to slide one more time. The crash did not stop Stan from the thrill of the ride. And, the taste of the cold wind and splash of snow and slush would not end his fun.

The time went by fast and the next thing they knew, it was very late. The sun was about to fade so they made one last run down the big hill. By this time, it was quite cold on the slope, but this last run was to be the best. It was a great way to end the day. Kate and Stan were done with their fun, and they pulled their sleds back to the shed until next time.

Mittens the Cat Strikes Again

With his black and white stripes, my pet Mittens is a cute cat for sure. But, do not let that trick you! We are used to the fact that Mittens often gets into things and makes quite a mess.

One day, Mittens moved the lid on the trashcan. Then, he removed the waste and junk from the trash bag and left it all over the tile. We were very much in shock when we came home to find our rubbish everywhere!

Another time, Mittens was seen jumping into the sink. He pushed the tap with his nose and had a sip of water. We thought, “How did he come up with a trick like that!”

Mittens also likes to move and hide things on us. He takes our socks and puts them in the bathtub or on our beds. What does Mittens do when he is done with this kind of joke? Well, I will tell you. He takes a very long nap!

Now, I must ask you this, “Would you like to have a cat like Mittens?”

A Hike at Jackson Lake

Miles woke up and moved fast to get to his friend Dave's home. They had plans to go for a hike around Jackson Lake. Miles and Dave knew they should hike with a pal to be safe. They always had a great time on these walks.

The two friends did not waste any time filling their backpacks with all the things they could use on a long hike. Miles had the drinks, snacks, and some spare socks. Dave had the sunblock and a map. When they were done, they made their way to the path by the lake.

Just past the bike racks, the pals pulled out their map. Dave led the way with a swift walk to the west side of the lake.

It took more than an hour to get there. The fish were jumping in the fresh lake water, and Dave and Miles sat down by the shore for a while. They ate their snacks and drank some water.

All too quick, it was time to go home. The land had been very wet in some spots, and they were sure glad they had a second set of socks for the trip home. They removed their wet socks and put on their spare ones.

On their way back, Dave and Miles saw a number of white ducks, wild rabbits, and one rare black falcon. This may have been their best hike yet!

The Cactus Plant Joke PART ONE

Mom has a lot of plants in her home and most of them do well. She uses great care and attends to them each day after work. As a joke, her son, Duke, moves a cactus plant under some blankets and away from the sun. Mom does not water the plant or see that it is missing at all.

Months go by and Duke also does not think about the plant that it is still hidden under the blankets. The sun does not shine on it and there is also a cold draft in the room. Will the plant fall victim to the drop in care and waste away?

Yes! The flat cactus spines are now tan with pink bumps sticking out everywhere. It is sure to fade fast if something is not done right away.

The Cactus Plant Joke PART TWO

One day, Mom grasps that her cactus plant is missing. She finds it when she pushes the blankets to the side. There is not much life left to the plant when she removes the blankets, and she is quite upset. Duke tells his mom that it was just a joke, and he now feels bad that the plant is so unwell. The effect of the joke was unintended, but still, Mom is very mad.

Is there hope for this sick plant? Is there anything that can be done? There sure is! Mom moves the plant to the front hall so it will get an extended sunbath. Then, she uses a big jug of fresh water to fill the pot. After five days, the spines and buds on the plant come back to life. At last, Mom smiles again! Duke is also glad that all is well in the end. He will think more before he plans his next joke.

Who will Dine with Hank?

Hank felt dismal as he sat at home. His wife, Kate, was away on a trip. Hank's day at work had been full of stress and he was not content to sit at home. It would be a shame to have another drab ham sandwich. He knew that it would not taste great and that made him crave some rich fare. Some lemon shrimp with chives would sure hit the spot! Now, he had just one problem - Hank did not like to dine out by himself.

Hank called his pal Ted, but Ted had plans to use his tickets to a basketball game. In spite of this misluck, Hank was intent on going to the Shrimp Grill to unwind and get a bite to eat.

The Shrimp Grill was just down the lane, and Hank always took care not to waste gas. So, he opted to walk this time. At the Shrimp Grill, Hank ran into Steve and Beth. He had not seen these two old friends for many months. Steve asked Hank to move over and dine with them. Hank was sure glad he did not have to dine by himself after all.

When everyone was done and the bill came, Hank gave his word that they would all pick a date to get together when Kate came back from her trip.

The Wire Contract PART ONE

Jane and Tom had to fix the wires in their old cabin by Lake Hamilton. They knew the wires in the walls were not safe or up to date. This snag was sure to pose a fire risk, and the scope of their problem was vast. All the wires did need to be removed. They also knew that the work must get done with skills both Jane and Tom did not possess. They were intent to hire the right person to get the cabin wires up to code.

Tom had the name of one man, but when he called, the man was insulting and quite rude. Jane and Tom had some time to spare, so they collected a number of bids for the contract. By the end of the month, they had gotten five quotes. Wouldn't you know - the rude man had granted the best quote! Did they dare to take the risk?

The Wire Contract PART TWO

Tom and Jane wanted to save some cash, but they did not want the rude man to bring them any stress. So, they gave the contract to the man with the second best quote. His name was Mr. Lund, and he said he could come make the cabin safe right away.

Mr. Lund did not waste any time. First he had to probe every wall. He pulled out all the busted wires and moved the fuse box. Next, he had to install new wires connecting the grid throughout the home.

When Mr. Lund said he was done, Tom and Jane inspected each signal just to be sure. In the end, they had used the best person for the chore. The talented Mr. Lund conducted a first rate job, and the cabin was safe to inhabit.

The Quake State

Dave inhabits a home out west in a state that is prone to quakes. Yet, in spite of this, he is glad to dwell there. In the past, quakes have hit many times and Dave has felt that there is not much he can do to combat this problem. The quakes have not lasted long, but it is no joke. They can shake things up for miles and miles!

The jolt of a quake can come with a sudden thrust. Dave wastes no time to make his home as safe as he can. He inspects the gaps and makes a plan for fixing these. He must get things up to code. He makes note of any object that could fall. He moves some things, and to others he attaches a strap one by one.

He connects the new gas stove and uses a clamp that flexes. Then, all the closets get new locks and bolts.

Next, Dave gets a plastic tub where he stores all the recommended things to have in a pinch. When he is done with this distress kit, he gets his contact list up to date. In this zone, Dave does expect another quake to happen. He cannot guess the time when it will strike, but he is sure his plan can lessen the impact.

The Limestone Cave

After class, Steve ran to get his friend, Bev, to make plans to explore a cave. Then they went to go find Gabe to invite him too. Gabe was glad and felt that it would be fun to explore a limestone cave. Bev, Steve, and Gabe met in the basement of Bev's home to talk some more.

"Is the cave safe?" asked Steve.

"I think it is. I hope it is!" said Gabe. "Let's take some rope and a camping lamp, just in case," said Bev.

The next day, they took a walk to go find the cave. Inside the limestone cave, the rocks were damp and felt like paste because sunshine never hit the inside of the cave. It was a good thing that Gabe took the lamp with him.

“I am always brave,” said Bev. “Let’s go in.”

Steve put his forearm on the side of the cave.
He felt something lifelike move against his skin.

“Quick, shine the lamp here!” he said.

“What is it?” asked Bev. “Let me take a look.”

“I know it’s a bat!” said Steve.

“A bat! That is a bat for sure! Let’s move!”

Gabe, Bev and Steve ran away fast to escape the bat cave. They ran the entire way to the lake and fell right on the grass. “We had fun. However, it was a mistake to think we were brave,” said Steve. “I dislike that cave because of the bats!”

The Caveman Exhibit

In mid-June, Mr. Jones took his second-grade class to a new caveman exhibit. To get there, the class had to go on a long drive. The bus was hot, and it felt like they would never get there. However, when the clock struck nine, they had made it to the exhibit hall!

The exhibit was all about the extinct cavemen who once had a campsite on a hillside in their very state. The kids found out that the cavemen made many campfires and often went fishing on the shoreline. They used homemade fishline and it was very strong. They got so many fish with it that they had lots of food and never went unfed.

The kids saw how the cavemen made clothes out of snakeskin and other kinds of reptile skins. The cavemen had a good life up on the hillside until misluck struck them in an instant.

First, there were bad wildfires that tore through the campsite. Sometime after the wildfires, landslides made the hillside unsafe. That may have led to the end of many of the cavemen. Those that made it through the landslides had to forego their life on the hillside and find new lands. Fossils and other things were collected from the site to be used in the show. The exhibit made the cavemen come back to life!

Kendall and the Cleveland Pride

Kendall is a great athlete. She likes to compete, so she runs track, and she is in the baseball and tennis clubs as well. However, foremost on Kendall's list of things she likes is basketball! She has a lot of talent and can make any kind of basketball shot. When she explodes at the rim with a slam dunk, the fans go wild!

Kendall's dad knows how much she likes basketball. She does well in her classes and stands out in all of her athletic clubs. Because she works nonstop, Kendall's dad tells her that she is getting a special gift. He is going to take her to a Cleveland Pride basketball game. He has two tickets just for them.

Kendall never ever felt so glad. She looks up to those athletes so much, and she has never been to a Pride game.

Kendall and her dad wake up at sunrise and make the long trip to Cleveland. They dine on sandwiches and milkshakes at lunchtime. The food and drinks taste good. When they get to the game, Kendall is so glad. She stares at the big-time athletes as they run, collide, and take extreme shots. Kendall takes notes in her mind so she can work on her own jump shots, blocks, and passes. She and her dad have so much fun and talk nonstop about the game on the ride home.

The Empire Lake Trip

Zeke and Dave are best friends. Because it will be more fun for Zeke, his parents have asked Dave to come on a camping trip with them. They are going to Empire Lake, and Zeke and Dave cannot wait. The forecast calls for sun and they have a list of fun things to do when they get to the campsite. Here's how they think things will go.

On the way to Empire Lake, Dad will stop at the store to pick up food and drinks. When they get to the lake, they will unpack and put up Dad's big, handmade tent. Next, they will dig a small hole for a campfire. Zeke's mom will set up a clambake, and they can munch and rest as the sun sets on the water. They will sit and tell chilling tales at bedtime.

At sunrise, Dad is going to make pancakes for everyone. Then, they will grab the fishline and walk down to the lake. With a bit of luck, they can net more than just tadpoles! After they fish, swim and sunbathe by the lakeside, they will go to the old drive-in for a film and milkshakes.

On their last day at Empire Lake, Zeke and Dave will hike up the never-ending hillside and look for reptiles. Then, they will take one more long dip in the lake before they drive home. Zeke and Dave hope it will be the best trip ever!

The Big Upset

Ed and Tim had a basketball game against the state champs, the Tomcats. They had to rush because there was a strict rule about being on time. Mr. Duke, the coach, would stress if anyone was ever late.

It was a big game. Ed strode to the line to take the tip. He was not tall in size, but he was a gifted athlete and he could jump. Ed hit the ball to Tim, who moved to the left and took a fine shot to ignite his team.

There was not much time left on the clock and it was neck and neck. Both sides had talent and a strong will to compete.

In the last seconds of the thrilling contest, Ed made a good pass to Tim.

In an instant, Tim was at the basket extending his hand to the rim. Then, Tim was hit as a Tomcat took a swipe at the ball. However, the ball still went in. The ref gave credit for the basket and called a foul! This was not a call the Tomcats could dispute.

Tim went to the line to try to score one more time. The Tomcats had made a big mistake. Tim's shot could win the contest, and the time on the clock was about to expire. He did not panic as he bent down and used his legs to help put the ball up. It was done - the shot went right in! Everyone in the stands took to their feet. What a game! What an upset!

Tom and the Complex Math PART ONE

Tom could not cope with his math homework problems. He intended to finish them by the end of math class, but he got none of them done. He was not using an excuse for not doing the work. To be quite frank, it was very unlike Tom because he never did miss a task. There was no dispute about the fact that Tom was upset.

At lunch, he took a walk and went to inquire of Mr. Jones, the math teacher. “I have spent a long time on this and consulted my math book. In spite of that, I admit that this math still frustrates me,” said Tom. “Whenever I subtract, the numbers come up as invalid. I cannot unravel the entire problem, and now my grade is at stake!”

“Well,” said Mr. Jones, “These problems are quite complex. I do advise you to check with your classmate Jim. He is the all-time best at this kind of math. I suspect that a lot of kids want help with this as well. I also intend to do the problems, step by step, today in class.”

“Tom, you will still get credit for the work because you came to talk with me,” said Mr. Jones. “I am glad that you can ask for help whenever you get stuck. I will check in with you in class.”

“Thanks,” said Tom. “I will be sure to ask Jim to help me after I gulp down my food.”

Tom and the Complex Math PART TWO

Standing in front of the class the next day, Mr. Jones said, “Look, the cause of your stress is that these problems are very complex! It is not rote math. I suspect that many of you spent hours on this.”

“Yes!” said both Sanchez and Jake. “Most of the class did not finish, and we used our math books!”

One kid told Mr. Jones that he used his dad’s software to try to work out the problems. It took until nine p.m., but it was a waste of time in the end because he also got stuck. Some kids then went on to admit that they had just opted to quit.

“Well, try not to panic or gripe. I know none of you are slacking off. Please put your books away for now. I shall walk you through the problems and inspect them step by step. I am sure that this will remove all the stress,” said Mr. Jones as he gave Tom a wink.

Pothole Problems

The west side of Flag St. had a big pothole in the concrete, and this was a problem for the commute. Anyone attempting to go to the west side of campus tended to drive on Flag St. Now, however, their travel was unsafe. The hole had been there for over a month, and it still was not fixed.

One day, a bus fell in the vast gap and got a flat tire. This would now stall everyone's drive for a good while. It had been an extreme mistake to ignore the problem, and it did cause an unexpected traffic mess. People were in an uproar! They were quite upset because nothing had been done to establish a fix for the problem.

The very next day, the public works staff was sent to end the snag. They used a chisel to pull out the chunks of rock. They took great care to not disrupt the flagstones on the sidewalk. The water and waste inside the hole was removed next. Then they pushed fresh gravel into the hole. To conclude, they had to tamp it down to be sure there was a solid bond and level top.

People were once more content. Their drive home, to work, or anywhere was now safe!

Trish and the Lemonade Stand

Trish sets up a lemonade stand on hot days. She distributes cold drinks to those who stop to take a taste. She likes to make people smile, but she does not intend to make a lot of cash. In fact, she contributes all of her profits to the public food bank.

It takes a lot of work to make a good lemonade stand. Trish moves an old desk and uses it to set up her stand. She illustrates a note to hang on the desk. This way, people who pass by will know what's for sale. Then, she and her dad put water, lemons, and lemonade mix together in a big jug.

People everywhere know about Trish. Oftentimes, they rave that her homemade lemonade is the world's best! So, Trish and her dad must make a lot of this cold drink.

The cups go, one by one, as people come by to sip and talk. Before long, there is nothing left in the jug. Trish packs up her stand, and once again she is pleased with the way the day went. She thanks her dad for the help and plans to sell her lemonade all throughout the year!

A Spot for the Bikes PART ONE

Steve is ten years old and his bike is now too small for him. But today, his mom is going to the bike shop with him to get a new one! They pick out a bike that is just the right size, and Steve is pleased. It is a red bike with a velvetlike seat. The bike's pedals, brakes, and tires are top of the line!

Once Steve and his mom get back from the bike shop, Dad is quick to recognize the pride Steve has in his new bike. Steve calls his pals and asks them to come over to check out his new bike. Then, Steve sees that his dad looks upset when he says, "Just don't let

me find a bunch of bikes left in the path of my truck. I will be home from work at six, and I do not want to run them over by mistake.”

Steve calls to mind the time he left his sled out and his dad ran it over. This fact is sure to contribute to Dad’s forecast about the bikes. Can Steve come up with a way to keep the bikes safe?

A Spot for the Bikes PART TWO

Dad's strict tone has made Steve think about how to solve his problem. He does not want to disinvite his friends, but where will all the bikes go? It will be lame to just drop them down on the grass or on the concrete. When Steve's friends come over, he wastes no time telling them about his plan. "We are going to build a custom-made bike rack! That way, whenever you come over to hang out, everyone will have a spot to put their bike." Steve illustrates the rack and writes out the steps to his plan.

Next, Steve distributes a job to everyone.

Altogether, they work on the project for most of the day, using scraps of metal, rope, and some bricks.

They construct a homemade bike rack in no time at all! When Steve's dad comes home from work, he admits at once that the bike rack pleases him. He says, "You kids demonstrate great skill. Now, there is no problem. My truck and all of your bikes each have their own spot!"

Calvin, the Sled Dog

It is a sunlit day, and the dogsled contest is all set to happen. Calvin, the sled dog, knows he is in good shape to contribute and command the pack. This past year Calvin has pulled Mr. Cunningham's sled to win after win. He must demonstrate his skills one more time!

How will he compare to the other sled dogs? Foremost, Calvin and his pack recognize that they have to be fast. Calvin wants to please Mr. Cunningham. He knows that some legs of the trip will be uphill, and the cold winds will sting them. It will be a test to see if Calvin can get the dogs in his pack to all work together.

A tall man will distribute the spots at the starting line. Once the signal goes off, the sled dogs will run, and Mr. Cunningham will yell the word, “Mush!”

Mr. Cunningham plans to stop every once in a while so the dogs can rest and have some food. But, nothing will stop Calvin from crossing the finish line first!

Jane's Pup is Hit

Jane's day is not going well at all. Her pocket-sized pup, Spot, is just two years old and likes to go for walks. Jane and the pup make their way down to the crosswalk. Then, a van makes a sudden move and collides with the pup. It is a blindside! This shocking mishap devastates Jane.

She holds Spot to try and stop his grunts and whines. Jane has to contemplate a way to put a custom-made sling together. She unzips her bag and finds a sash. In an instant, she attaches it to Spot's leg and makes sure he does not move. The pup has a sad gaze and Jane does her best to console him.

With no time to waste, Jane drives to the pet clinic with Spot. The vet is quick to recognize the problem right away and has to tranquilize Spot. Jane bides her time, however, she is full of distress. She has been there for over two hours!

At last, the vet comes out with Spot. Jane's stress diminishes once she sees Spot. The pup wakes up and gives Jane a content look. Nothing pleases her more than to know that Spot will be all right in the end.

Josh and Todd Make a Profit

Josh is a whiz with websites. Together with his best friend, Todd, they get contracts to update websites and make new ones too. Most years, they demonstrate a solid profit. They recognize the time that it takes to concoct and embellish the websites with great snapshots and text. They never rush and always commit themselves to contribute both their time and talent to each task. These attributes help Josh and Todd expand their website work.

Last month, they had a big stroke of luck. Dr. Ross, a dentist, had plans for a website but did not have the skillset to complete the job.

Dr. Ross gave Josh and Todd a call, and they told him that nothing would please them more than to make a fantastic website for him. However, they would have to get together to go over Dr. Ross' wish list and contemplate the best way to address his website.

Once they began the job, it did not take as much time as they thought it would. Altogether, it only took six days to construct the content for the website. When they were done, Dr. Ross had to admire their work and gave Josh and Todd a handsome sum. He said that he would subscribe to their work again. They had made Dr. Ross glad, and they also made a big profit!

Anton's Bake Shop PART ONE

Anton wants to be the boss of a bake shop. Everyone knows about his talent with cupcakes and muffins. However, the most important thing he bakes is custom cakes. His frosting is world class stuff!

After a year of looking, Anton has found the right spot to rent! It's a small place and it is a bit run-down, but he thinks he can make it impressive. He pulls together twelve of his friends and asks them to take part in getting the spot looking attractive again.

Anton puts his friends to work on the extensive job right away. First, they remove an old shelf and put up a new one. Then, they give the place a fresh and distinctive look throughout. Gold blinds are hung on metal rods, and a bell is hung at the front of the shop. It is a productive day. Anton takes a long look around the shop and is so pleased!

Anton's Bake Shop PART TWO

The next day, Anton goes to the town common and distributes ads about his new bake shop. He wants to take an active part and make sure the shop is a big hit. The ad says that anyone who comes to his new place will get a red velvet cupcake! It is expensive to give away products, but it is important because it will be good for sales in the end.

The big day comes and Anton has frosted all of the cupcakes. By ten a.m., Anton has a shop full with people! Anton is attentive to everyone as they taste all of his fresh food. The public is pleased, and they think his cakes are impressive. His plan has been quite effective. In fact, he sells all his goods in one day. Now it is time to bake again!

A Pig Who Does Not Like Mud?

We all know that pigs just love mud. In fact, they spend a lot of time swishing around in the stuff. Piglets also like to involve themselves in fun in the muck.

It is not very attractive, but it can help them be cool when it's hot outside. The mud can also be an effective sunblock for their pink skin and play an important part in helping to get rid of ticks and other bugs.

One day, the pigs at Mr. Nelson's ranch were once again in the massive mud pit. Well, most of the pigs were in the pit. One very small piglet, called Grime, did not want to take part in this wild mud flop.

With a name like Grime, you would think he would be the first piglet to jump in the mud. However, Grime sat off to the side. He was not pleased with all the mess around him! He did not care if it was a pig rule, he would not be found in that dense pit of mud.

Mr. Nelson was attentive to his pigs, and he knew that he must involve Grime in games. He pushed and pulled Grime with no luck. After a while, Grime's mom came over and gave an immense grunt. In an instant, Grime set off to the mud pit. The instructive command had been effective. It was important for Grime to get in the mud and have fun. And, that he did!

The Not-So-Impressive Date PART ONE

Jake called Olive and made a date to dine at the grand banquet. The festive night would bring cash to a good cause. Olive was rich and quite distinctive. Jake felt it was important to impress her, and he wanted to demonstrate that he had polish and class.

Jake found himself some expensive pants and an attractive new jacket. Then he made sure he had a close shave. Jake suspected that Olive may not recognize him after all this.

When Jake made it to Olive's place to pick her up, she was pleased about his look. Jake and Olive drove to the banquet and met up with Steve and Jan. That evening was sure to be a step up from most of Jake's dates.

The Not-So-Impressive Date PART TWO

It did not take too long for Jake to be back to his old self again. When the banquet food came, he was distracted and altogether inattentive. He did not place a good grip on his plate. This made him drop a massive pile of spareribs on his lap. His expensive pants were now a complete mess!

Jake's mistakes prompted Steve, Jan, and Olive to poke fun at him. They said he was disruptive, but Jake did not think it was important. He always wanted to be constructive, so he let them joke and stare.

When the band ended their last song, Olive gave Jake a big kiss. In fact, Olive did still like Jake, in spite of his immense mess. On his part, Jake was glad that Olive was not a snob and was pleased that they both found jest in the date.

Gavin's Gift

Gavin is in tenth grade and has impressive skills constructing just about anything. He can tell you how to install a pump valve and consult with you about fixing any object.

Gavin also knows about truck parts - drive shafts, cranks, and pedals. Gavin helps everyone around him solve problems over and over again. Nothing is too complex for him. He uses one gimmick after another to be effective. He delves into the task and does not stop working until everything is sound and back in place.

Gavin uses his wisdom to do good for others. At his own expense, he mends busted objects for his friends. Gavin is also attentive to his dad's truck and checks the tires and fan belt without being asked.

His talent is somewhat compulsive, but Gavin knows it is important to give back. He often walks around town and extends a hand to anyone in need. One day, he moved a ranch wagon that had gotten stuck in a massive hole. Helping people makes him glad. Gavin wants to live in a world where people never stop helping one another.